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Know Ajay Srinivasan better



Clip

VIKAS KUMAR

TIMES NEWS NETWORK [FRIDAY, DECEMBER 03, 2004 01:21:42 AM]

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At Prudential ICICI he shot to prominence as one of the leading names in the country's fledgling mutual fund industry and soon was offered a job with the parent company itself.

However, Srinivasan found his elevation to a regional position, where he now handles business worth \$35 billion, to be a bigger challenge than he had imagined.

"The opportunity to do something across Asia was a great challenge. It was virtually a blank sheet of paper with a chance for me to put my stamp on it," he says.

There was very little time to lose, and Srinivasan was expected to hit the ground running by his then boss Mark Tucker (the former head of Prudential's Asian business) who he remembers as being a "very impatient" and aggressive man.

More than that, his new role demanded not only broadening his horizon from a single market focus to multiple markets, but also dealing with some of the problems that came along with it.

Being a vegetarian, Srinivasan has had to be on his guard all the time, when eating out: "You can't even recognise what they serve." And being a non-smoker and teetotaler makes matters all the more difficult: "People cannot easily adjust to the fact that I don't drink."

Diversity is something that Srinivasan has had to learn to manage, not only outside but inside the organisation as well — his senior management team has people drawn from different nationalities, from British to Singaporean to Australian to

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Business review meetings are used as an opportunity for bonding, sharing experiences and best practices and indulging in some sporting action too, each time in a different country. Last March it was night cricket at the Mumbai Police Gymkhana, and before that soccer in Korea, beach volleyball in Singapore and go-karting in Malaysia.

On the brighter side, Srinivasan has also realised that his India experience has been a big advantage at work: "The Indian market is, in some ways, more advanced in comparison to other markets.

So transfer of knowledge to other markets was easier." The challenges though, remained the same — as far as investment options went, a majority of consumers weren't thinking beyond the traditional bank deposit route: "In Asia two-thirds of personal financial assets typically go into bank deposits.

" However, with evolving demographics and social structures, Srinivasan says that the mindset is now changing.

Putting in an average of 12 hours, Srinivasan's workday begins relatively early at 7:30 after he drops his two children off at school.

His wife, a former batchmate at IIM Ahmedabad, who had been with HLL in Mumbai, now works with Unilever in Hong Kong. A self-confessed sports freak, Srinivasan regularly plays in league cricket matches in Hong Kong.

Evenings are strictly reserved for family. "Family support is a very important part of my life," he says.

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